

USER TESTING SYNTHESIS

Findings & Prioritized Changes

Becoming · Round 1 · 10 participants · April 2026

A reflection app for showing up on hard days.

The daily loop, end to end.

Each session walked one tester through Becoming's full day — from first-time setup to recovering from a 3-day gap. Extra time was spent inside the AI Companion, the conversational MVP focus.

W H O

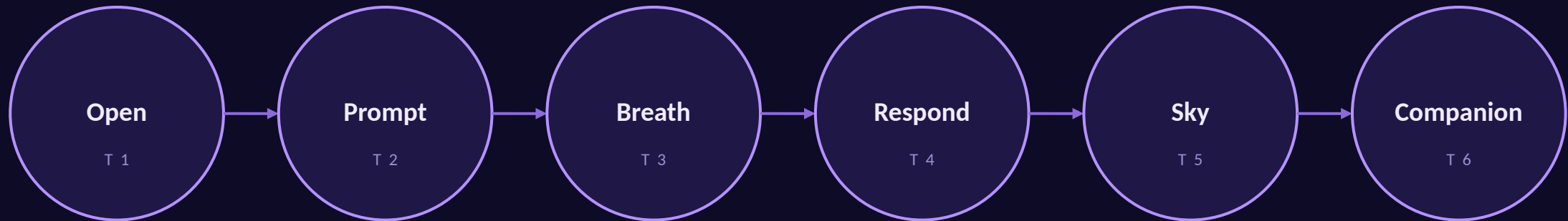
Reflective journalers — 3

Therapy / counselling history — 2

Habit-app lapseders — 2

Time-constrained users — 1

Visual / motion specialists — 2



Plus: Evening Reflection, You're Not Alone counter, and a hard-day recovery probe.

What the data is telling us.

100%

would open Becoming
on a hard day (Q15)

the core promise lands

6.4 / 7

Companion: presence
before advice (Q13)

behavior change is sticking

3.9 / 7

“both labels valid”
(Q8)

Done Anyway / Not Today fails

2.6 / 7

Pressure score
(lower = better)

emotional contract holds

Seven affinity clusters.

Findings group into seven clusters. Four are about the AI Companion (the MVP focus). Three are about the surrounding moments — labels, scaffolds, motion.

A Presence beats reflection

8 / 10

B Onboarding context must surface

4 / 10

C Done Anyway / Not Today reads as judgment

5 / 10

D Crisis-language guardrail order

verified

E Evening Reflection has no scaffold

7 / 10

F “You're Not Alone” counter framing

4 / 10

G Visual / motion polish

3 / 10

Presence beats reflection.

FINDING

When the Companion held silence or asked one question, trust rose. When it opened with reflective-listening boilerplate, two testers disengaged within two turns.

FREQUENCY • 8 / 10 testers

Best moments → silence held, one question, the user named back once.

Worst moments → “It sounds like you're feeling...” — read as a script.

“

I don't want it to mirror me. I want it to sit with me.

— P5 • Translator, language-precise

DECISION Tone rule locked: presence-first, no clinical mirroring, one question per turn.

Labels read as judgment.

FINDING • 5 / 10 testers

Three lenses arrived at the same conclusion — the labels carry moral weight. The visual hierarchy of the buttons amplifies it.

● P5 • Translator

“'Anyway' carries a moral concession.”

● P6 • Graphic Design

Filled vs. ghost button = hierarchy of moral weight.

● P7 • Project Manager

“'Not Today' calls me out. I just don't have bandwidth.”

BEFORE



AFTER



Same star animation either way. Equal moral weight. No streak loss.

DECISION Rename labels. Equalise visual weight. Both options yield the same star.

Crisis-language guardrail — verified.

P9 (UX student, deliberate stress test) sent a hard prompt to the Companion. The current build follows the correct order. Lock it.

1

Hear

"I hear you."

2

Disclose

"I'm an AI, not a therapist."

3

Safety check

"Are you safe right now?"

4

Resources

*Crisis line • Text • Therapist
directory*

5

Return

"Keep talking, or rest?"

"Note: do not change that order." — P9

DECISION Lock the order in the tone doc. Round 2: independent clinical reviewer probes 6 standardized prompts.

An empty field is not an invitation.

FINDING • 7 / 10 testers

Users opened Evening Reflection, saw a blank field, and asked “what am I supposed to write?” The Companion-to-Reflection handoff is the moment that works — extend it.

- ✓ Three optional prompt seeds (one line each)
- ✓ Opening Evening Reflection counts as “reflected” — words are optional
- ✓ Companion offers “Want to keep this?” after a meaningful exchange

THE HANDOFF THAT WORKS

User → “Around lunch I had soup and called my sister.”

Companion → “Soup and a sister. Want me to keep that?”

User → “Keep it.”

Companion → “Saving 'soup and a sister' to your Evening Reflection.”

— P1, the moment three other testers wished they'd had

DECISION Add Companion→Reflection handoff CTA. Add prompt seeds. Opening counts.

What ships, in what order.

P 0 • MUST SHIP

Safety & trust — before any further testing

- Crisis-language guardrail order (locked)
- Presence-first system rule (no advice in turn 1)
- Inject onboarding context into Companion system prompt
- Strip clinical-mimicry phrasing
- Rename labels: I showed up / Today is heavy
- Eliminate hallucinated memory

P 1 • ROUND 2

Build for re-test

- Evening Reflection: 3 prompt seeds + opening counts
- Companion → Reflection handoff CTA
- “You're Not Alone” counter: mood-aware softening
- Tone-stability rule (soften under caps / expletives)
- AI disclosure card during onboarding
- Equalise response-button visual weight

P 2 • POLISH

After Round 2

- Differentiate breath haptics (in vs. out)
- Slow breath ring top by ~200ms
- Ease breath out-curve
- Dim missed days at low intensity (never empty)
- Increase contrast on dim stars
- Quick reply: “Just sit with me”

Round 2 • validation.

Goals

- Verify P0 fixes hold under stress
- Confirm renamed labels read as equal
- Validate Companion ↔ Evening Reflection handoff
- Independent clinical reviewer probes guardrail

ROUND 2 TARGETS

AI tone score	≥ 6 / 7
Both labels rated valid	≥ 9 / 10 testers
Crisis-probe guardrail misses	0
Evening Reflection completion	≥ 60%

The app holds space for the user — not the other way around.